

# Moonsea Rising - 20240810

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## The Harkening

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Beitris -- Rose Red -- offers Harken the final choice. He can be released, now, or he can depart. Harken disappears, but Rose's eye's glow a bright red, following the spectre. He messages her, asking her continued mercy for his condition. Her face hardens, but her resolve is clear. He ducks through the wreckage, trying to keep it between himself and the priestess, now of the god of duty -- and vengeance. Resignedly, he messages her that he will leave. Under her breath she says, "another time, then. I will see you at rest." Using his powers, he winks his skull out of the wreckage and begins dragging it off into the countryside.<sup>[1]</sup>

Taevyn and Lennox both notice the cast of her shoulders and approach her. She tells them Harken as fled, referring to him as "it," lest she destroy him. The other men accept this with concern, but both trust the priestess. Taevyn, in particular, seems a little upset with the conflict, but Rose hugs him, and he accepts it. Lennox wraps his arms around both of them.

Banging erupts from the wrecked dining car. Lirael approaches, checking for the elemental core. It's present, but the banging is coming from its position in the car. Lennox and Taevyn enter the car, finding a banging noise coming from one of the meat coolers. A middle-aged man in leathers rolls out of the cooler, bounding to his feet. He looks at Lennox and tells him, "whomever you are, don't go drinking with halflings. Aren't you a little big for a halfling?" He managed to completely miss the wreck, sleeping off his drunk in the cooler. Taevyn introduces himself, and the man, -- Maximillian Handy -- introduces himself as a "bard extraordinaire!" The man vomits extravagantly against the side of the overturned traincar, protesting his perfect health all the while.

Nikolai comes over and tells them he hasn't found any sign of Glimmerknock in the crash, which is completely out of character for the gnomish madman. Baron Tuskclaw agrees with this, and discussions of Tris' involvement with the Zhentarim. Maximillian seems to be completely unaware that her was even on the Ironride, and mentions that he heard someone talking about packages and someone named "Virgil," during brief moments of lucidity.

Lirael is concerned about the elemental cores, and consulting with Clementh and Hermiphony thinks the major cores can remain in the engine until salvage arrives, and the smaller cores can be more easily collected. Tuskclaw says they need to find Glimmerknock if they hope to get the Ironride running again. Lirael points out that Glimmerknock might well be a puppet of the Zhentarim, which makes recovering him even more important.

Taevyn offers to backtrack the train to look for where Glimmerknock was taken, and the others join him, of course. Max asks to tag along, seeing the seeds of an epic story in the offing. Before they leave, Rose goes to Nikolai, casting a spell of status on him, kissing the man before they part. Clarissa seems shocked by this display, quickly turning sour and walking off. Max nudges Lennox and asks him if he knows who Uriah and Nikolai are. Lennox says he does, and Max drops it. He instead asks if he has any drink, and takes it gratefully when offered.

# Gnomolocation

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The party moves down the track, looking for signs of Glimmerknock's exfiltration. There is precious little to find, until Rose and Lennox both notice a tree with upside-down branches and a nearby patch of trampled ground. Checking the tree, they find a blind intended to cover the course of a path into the forest.

Exploring with some caution, they find a clearing with steps carved into the rock face, leading up. Stopping by the edge of the trees, Taevyn cautiously creeps up to, and up, the steps, peering carefully over the top. Two women in green and brownish robes are hiding in bushes on the next flat level up. Moving carefully, Taevyn moves back down and returns to the others, describing what he's seen.

It doesn't sound like a Zhent trap, but caution is truly warranted. Rose suggests she and Lirael approach, cautiously, and attempt to parley in case they are peaceful. Max offers to come with them, and he and Rose debate the relative merits, while Lirael is looking around for signs and sigils. All signs point to a druid circle, and that they'll be unable to approach stealthy. Lirael opts to call out of them in fey that they have come in peace, and are simply looking for something. They tell them to approach with weapons sheathed and hands up.

They do, and the head druidess asks why they've intruded on the Shadowbark Druids' circle. Lirael asks if they've seen anyone with a struggling gnome come through their lands, and she denies it. Rose notices furtive glances to left and right, and thinks something might be amiss. She quietly responds, "not true. Watch the plinths." Lirael peers ahead and sees shadows. Her spirit-sense detects people behind each of the three stones. She tells the druidess in fey, "we will leave, but if the people behind the stones are a problem, send us a signal." She tells the others, "we should go." They follow her lead, and within seconds a bird lands on a tree near them. In fey, it speaks, saying, "Zhentarim. Help."

Lirael tells them the bird has indicated Zhents and she detected three people, one behind each stone. She suggests that they find a different approach, and they quietly circle the rise, finding an unguarded approach from the back. Max offers to form a magical staircase, which he quickly does. Taevyn crouches, climbing the steps and peering over the top. Seven zhents, all facing the stairs on the other side. Taevyn becomes invisible, creeping up to the nearest one and preparing a strike. Max renders Lennox invisible as well, and the man tries to follow, but steps on a branch, just over the top lip. The nearest Zhents turn, weapons drawn, peering into the forest.

Max snaps another branch, off to the side, hoping to turn the Zhents in the wrong direction, which they do. Lennox steps up to his target, viciously swinging his axe and catching the man fully off-guard. Two strikes leave the man bleeding and at death's door, as the other Zhents turn towards him. The man nearest Taevyn moves away from Lennox, firing two poorly-aimed bowshots at him. A fusillade of arrows rains down around the big man, several striking him various blows.

Lirael rockets into the air, crashing to the ground behind two of the Zhents, spraying them with rock and fire. Air bursts from around her, knocking the nearest man off the ledge, and he grunts as he falls to the ground. Taevyn tumbles past the man Lennox was killing, and stabs him with his rapier. His follow-up misses, and the Zhent continues to draw breath. He draws a potion from his belt, but Lennox swings his axe, dispatching the man before he can drink it.

Almost as one woman, the druids begin a chant. The stones begin to hum with magical power. Lirael recognizes a water spell about to shoot from the stones. Max bounds up, playing a rousing song on his mandolin. Lennox charges the man by Lirael, hitting him with his axe. Lennox kicks him off the ledge, and he falls, hitting the Zhent trying to climb back up.

Rose steps up next to Taevyn, glaring down one of the Zhents. The man looks shaken, as the Zhents unleash a volley of arrows at the angry priestess.

Lirael tells them to get away from the stones, and casts, turning into a massive unicorn. She moves to the center of the camp, trying to get some cover from the tents. Taevyn rushes the shaken Zhent, cutting the man deeply, leaving him bleeding, and sweeping up into a parry.

Water explodes inward from the plinths in massive cones, hitting Lirael, Rose, Glimmerknock, and one of the Zhents. Lirael rears, the jet missing her, as Rose rolls to one side. Glimmerknock and the Zhent are blasted aside, shifting across the camp. Max strums an usual tune, and several small crowds appear throughout the camp, cheering him on and confusing everyone else.

Lennox continues rushing about like a bull in a china shop, striking the nearest Zhent with his axe. Rose moves to the nearest tent, healing herself. The Zhents try to switch to melee, but are rather less dangerous in that way. The Liraelicorn leaps over the tent, spearing the nearest Zhent with her horn. Taevyn calls to Rose, flaunting the ease with which he finds fighting the Zhents, and skewers the bleeding man next to him again. Turning from the bleeding man, he slashes at the other man, opening another gaping wound.

The druids cast a series of entangling spells, capturing the wounded and nearly dead Zhents in their vines. Two of the Zhents are still alive when the party gets to interrogation, though the two off the cliff had managed to escape.

## Media

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1. [Let Harken Go↩](#)